RELIGION AND MORALITY

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I do not share the view of Nietzsche, Sartre, and some Christian Evangelicals that if God did not exist, then everything would be permitted. Nor do I believe that, as a matter of empirical fact, if religion were to disappear, morality would collapse. I do think that the ontological and epistemic relations between religion and morality are tighter than some secular thinkers suppose. I will support this claim by sketching two arguments. The first contends that theists have good reasons for identifying moral facts with divine commands (or something else of the sort). The second argues that anyone who believes that moral values are objective has at least some reason for adopting theism or some other religious position.

First argument

Important strands of the Christian tradition stress God's absolute sovereignty. This emphasis is particularly clear in Augustine, William of Ockham, Martin Luther, and John Calvin. It is also an important theme in Islam and in Dvaita Vedanta. If God's sovereignty is indeed unlimited and unqualified, as these traditions attest, then there is nothing distinct from God on which he is dependent and nothing distinct from him which is not dependent on him. It seems to follow that moral truths aren't independent of God. If God is truly sovereign, his will must somehow make them true or constitute the moral facts which they express.

For suppose it doesn't, and that God's will is wholly or partly determined by independent standards of value. If it is, then God's activity is not wholly *self*-determined; he is subject to things that exist independently of him.

And in fact, leaving questions of divine dependence aside, the very existence of independent moral and value facts compromises God's sovereignty. For if essences, eternal truths (including moral truths), values, and the like aren't "part" of God or created by him, then God's sovereignty does not extend over all being. So by making moral facts dependent on God's will, divine command theory effectively protects his sovereignty—and, for theists, this is an important consideration in its favor.

Divine command theory is vulnerable to two powerful objections, however. First, the theory seems to imply that in logically possible worlds in which God fails to exist or commands nothing, such things as promise-keeping or fidelity wouldn't be obligatory, and gratuitous cruelty, treachery, and the like wouldn't be forbidden. It seems to many of us, however, that promise-keeping and fidelity would be *prima facie* obligatory in *all* possible circumstances, and that gratuitous cruelty and treachery would be forbidden. Moreover, to make matters worse, divine command theories seem to imply that not only might things like gratuitous cruelty be permitted, they might even be obligatory. For if divine command theories are true, then if God *were* to command gratuitous cruelty, gratuitous cruelty would be morally obligatory. Yet surely one of our most deeply entrenched moral intuitions is that there is *no* possible world in which it would be *prima facie* obligatory to gratuitously inflict pain on others. In other words, "It is *prima facie* wrong to inflict gratuitous cruelty on another" appears to be a *necessary* truth.

Divine command theorists who believe that God is self-existent have a response to this: God necessarily exists and is such that in any possible world in which creatures like us exist, he commands them not to lie, to protect the innocent, and so on.[1] Robert Adams says that he doesn't "believe that there is a unique set of commands that would be issued by any supremely good God."[2] And this is surely correct. A supremely good God might, for example, issue one set of ritual commands in one possible world and another set in another. Yet this admission is fully consistent with claiming that there are *some* commands that any supremely good God would *necessarily* issue to beings sufficiently like us. The second table of the Decalogue is, arguably, an example. If moral obligations are best understood as divine commands, then these necessary moral truths can be construed as commands God necessarily issues in the appropriate circumstances.[3]

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[1] So, strictly speaking, what is necessarily true in worlds in which there are no appropriate recipients of a divine command such as protect the innocent (because no rational creatures exist in it or because in those worlds innocents can't be harmed) is that if there *were* beings like us, God would command them to protect the innocent, and hence they *would* have an obligation to do so.

[2] Robert Adams, *Finite and Infinite Goods: A Framework of Ethics* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1999), 255.

[3] One might doubt that necessity is compatible with willing but not everyone does. Aquinas, for example, thought that we necessarily will our own happiness, and Jonathan Edwards's theological premises commit him to the claim that God necessarily wills to create some world or other.

The second and more serious problem in my opinion is this. Ralph Cudworth argued that willing and commanding *as such* create no obligations; for willing or commanding creates obligations only when there is a *prior obligation to obey*, an obligation which is ultimately grounded in "natural justice or equity, which gives one [person] the *right* or *authority* of commanding, and begets in another *duty* and *obligation* to obedience." Willing or commanding, then, can't be the source of all obligations. If *all* obligation were grounded in God's will, then the obligation to obey God would be grounded in God's will. But it is "ridiculous and absurd" to suppose that "anyone would make a positive law that others should be obliged or bound to obey him; if they were obliged before, this law would be in vain, and to no purpose; and if they were not before obliged, they could not be obliged by any positive law because they were not previously bound to obey such a person's commands." If I already have an obligation to obey Mary's commands, for instance, it is pointless for her to command me to obey them. If I do not, then the mere fact that Mary tells me to do something puts me under no obligation to do it. It would seem, then, that even if God is the source of each of our *other* obligations, he cannot be the source of our obligation to obey God.[4]

Cudworth's argument is powerful and appears to leave the divine command theorist with only three alternatives. One is to limit the theory to obligations other than the obligation to obey God. The second is to deny that we are morally obligated to obey God's commands. The first involves abandoning the fine generality of the theory, and leaves at least one obligation (namely, our obligation to obey God) unaccounted for. The second alternative seems counterintuitive although the divine command theorist may be able to partially dispel this impression by providing reasons for obedience that are non-moral in the sense that they don't appeal to moral *obligations*. Some of these reasons may be moral in a broader sense, however, for moral goodness isn't exhausted by the morally obligatory. If my reason for obeying God is, for example, his love or fairness rather than his power, then my reason is moral in this wider sense.

The only other alternative that I can see is to insist that, unlike ours, the authoritativeness of God's commands is *intrinsic*; it doesn't rest on a freestanding obligation to obey him.[5]

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[4] Ralph Cudworth, *A Treatise Concerning True and Immutable Morality* (London: J & J Knapton, 1731), 17–20.

[5] The commands of a drill sergeant *qua* drill sergeant are intrinsically authoritative in this sense. (The bare fact that he issues them *qua* drill sergeant is a sufficient reason for

Second argument

The second reason why someone might want to be a divine command theorist is philosophical. It provides an account of the objectivity of moral values.

What conditions must be met if values are to be objective? First, value claims are either true or false. Second, values are universal. If something is *prima facie* good or right, it is *prima facie* good or right at all times and places. Third, values aren't products of our desires. The goodness of truthfulness or friendship, for example, can't be reduced to the fact that we desire it or would desire it if we were fully informed.

But while these conditions are necessary, they aren't sufficient. To be objective in the intended sense, values must also be part of the "furniture of the universe." Goodness and rightness, for example, must be real properties of the things that have them.[6]

J.L. Mackie has persuasively argued that a belief in the objectivity of moral values is embedded in most mainstream Western moral philosophy and is presupposed in ordinary moral thought and discourse. "The ordinary user of moral language means to say something about" the object that he "characterizes morally," and not about his or anyone else's attitudes toward it; he means "something that involves a call for action or for the refraining from action . . . that is . . . not contingent on desire or preference . . . or choice" of "his own or anyone else's."

There is also at least some reason to think that a belief in the objectivity of moral values is a natural concomitant of moral commitment. William James, for example, contrasts those who think "that the words 'good' and 'bad' [ultimately] have no sense apart from subjective passions and interests which we may, if we please, play fast and loose with at will . . .," and those who believe that moral facts are embedded in the structure of reality. The moral conduct of the two may be indistinguishable in most situations. But in what James calls the "lonely emergencies of life," in which

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obeying them.) No one essentially occupies the role of a sergeant, however. By contrast, God is essentially God. For a critique of the third alternative see Mark Murphy, *An Essay on Divine Authority* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 2002). For my critique of Murphy see my *Religion and Morality* (Aldershot [Eng.] and Burlington, VT: Ashgate, 2005), 136–140.

[6] The difference between people who believe in the objectivity of values and those who don't is, in this respect, like that between people who believe in the real existence of material substance underlying phenomenal qualities of color, shape, and so on, and phenomenalists or Berkeleyan idealists who do not. See J.L. Mackie, *Ethics: Inventing Right and Wrong* (Harmondsworth, England and New York: Penguin Books, 1977), chapter 1.

our ideals clash with our interests, the first will tend to adjust his ideals to his interests while the second will not. "Resistance then, poverty, martyrdom if need be, tragedy in a word,—such are the solemn feasts of his inward faith."[7]

What James' remarks suggest is that moral seriousness—a deep and unswerving commitment to the moral life regardless of what it may cost—presupposes a belief that morality is not only objective but part of the deep structure of reality, that the universe is, as James put it, a "moral universe." In other words, James thinks that there is a kind of incoherence in whole heartedly committing oneself to the moral life while denying that "the law of right and wrong is as much part and parcel of the structure of the universe as the law of gravitation or the law of conservation of energy."[8] For such a person "duty and reality are radically split asunder. He cannot be wholly serious about his" duty, for he knows that should he violate it, he won't be "living out of harmony with reality."[9]

Mackie himself thinks that the belief in objective values is mistaken. In the first place, value properties, if real, would be "queer" properties, "utterly different from everything else in the universe." Unlike other facts, moral facts would have either "requiredness" or "not-to-be doneness somehow built into" them, and an objective goodness would have "to-be-pursuedness somehow built into it." How features like these could be related to a thing's natural or empirical features, however, is a total mystery. In the second place, it is unclear how we could *know* these non-natural features since they don't stand in causal relations to us. (Values aren't causes.)

Mackie's response to these difficulties is to offer an error theory of objective value. By providing an explanation of our belief in the objectivity of values which doesn't appeal to their objectivity, he hopes to make any postulation of objective values seem otiose.[10] But given that an appearance of objectivity is an obvious feature of ordinary moral experience and

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[7] William James, "The Sentiment of Rationality," *The Will to Believe and Other Essays in Popular Philosophy* (New York, 1956), 103–105.

[8] A.E. Taylor, *Does God Exist?* (London: Macmillan, 1948), 96f.

[9] J.B. Stearns, "A Moral Argument," *Idealistic Studies* 8 (1978), pp. 200–201.

[10] Mackie argues that the belief in the objectivity of moral values can be explained by the mind's "propensity to spread itself on external objects" (Hume), i.e., by our projecting our attitudes on to their objects; by our tendency to reverse "the direction of dependence" between desires and goodness, "making the desire depend upon the goodness, instead of the goodness on the desire;" by our unconsciously suppressing the fact that statements of obligation are implicitly hypothetical (asserting that so-and-so should be done *if* we or others *want* such-and-such); by "the persistence of a belief in something like divine law when the belief in the divine legislator has faded out;" and the like.

practice, a belief in their objectivity would appear to be the default position. Other things being equal, their apparent objectivity is a good reason for thinking that moral values really *are* objective. So if theists can provide an explanation of moral values which respects the appearance of objectivity, and is at least as good an explanation of their apparent objectivity as Mackie's, then their apparent objectivity is a sufficient reason for preferring the theist's account to Mackie's.

Even if theists can do this, though, they aren't home free. For theistic accounts of the objectivity of moral values have rivals which preserve at least some of the appearances. Two of the most important are naturalism and constructivism. Naturalism identifies goodness, for example, with a natural (that is, empirical) property such as pleasure or happiness, or with a cluster of such properties. For instance, Richard Boyd identifies goodness with what he calls a "homeostatic property cluster"—"things which satisfy important human needs" together with the "homeostatic mechanisms which unify them."[11] Boyd doesn't think that "good" *means* "things satisfying important human needs together with the mechanisms which unify them." But he does think that this property cluster *constitutes* goodness, or is what goodness *really is.* (An analogy: "water" doesn't mean "H_2O." Nevertheless, H_2O constitutes water—it is what water really is.)

Naturalism has several advantages. Perhaps its most important is that it appears to make values robustly objective. In its view, values are ordinary empirical properties (or sets of them). They are thus part of the furniture of the universe, and claims about them are either true or false. Values also appear to be universal in the relevant sense. If goodness is identical with Boyd's homeostatic property cluster, for example, every instance of that property cluster is good regardless of where or when it is found.

Whether naturalism preserves *all* the appearances, however, is doubtful. Mackie has pointed out that moral facts as ordinarily understood have "requiredness" or "not-to-be-doneness" built into them, and that the property (or set of properties) picked out by "goodness" has "to-be-pursuedness" built into it. Yet it is difficult to see how purely empirical properties *could* have characteristics like these built into them. Suppose, for instance, that we identify goodness with the set of things which satisfy our more important wants and needs. Given that we *have* these wants and needs, we will pursue their satisfaction. But the to-be-pursuedness

[11] That is, mechanisms which ensure that the properties tend to produce or maintain the others when enough of them are present.

of the things that satisfy them appears, on this view, to be an artifact of our needs and wants, not an intrinsic feature of the things themselves. If so, then our third criterion of objectivity isn't met; values don't have the necessary independence from our desires and interests.

Constructivists believe that while there *are* moral facts or truths, these facts or truths are the *products* of rational deliberation and choice. For example, John Rawls argued that adequate principles of justice are those which would be chosen under fair conditions by rational agents concerned to maximize their share of things such as "rights and liberties, opportunities and powers, income and wealth," and "a sense of one's own worth." Christine Korsgaard believes that "value is founded in rational nature—in particular in the structure of reflective consciousness." Moral values are bound up with our "practical identity," descriptions under which we value ourselves, "find [our] life to be worth living and [our] actions to be worth undertaking."

On views like these, value claims are objective in the sense that they are true or false (or, alternatively, correct or incorrect, reasonable or unreasonable). Whether they meet the other conditions for objectivity is less clear.

Rawls came to admit that his procedures will yield the intuitively "correct" results only when applied to rational agents committed to the values of modern Western liberal democracies. The moral claims supported by the procedures aren't truly universal, then. And critics have accused Korsgaard of paying insufficient attention to the fact that the descriptions under which we value ourselves appear to vary from one person to another and from culture to culture. If they do, then appeals to them won't yield universal moral principles. The fourth condition isn't met either. Korsgaard, I think, speaks for all constructivists when she says that the value which "is grounded in . . . the structure of rational consciousness . . . is projected on to the world. So the reflection in question is practical and not theoretical: it is a reflection about what to do, *not reflection about what is to be found in the normative part of the world"* (my emphasis).[12]

By contrast, on a suitably qualified divine command theory, values meet all four of the conditions that must be satisfied if they are to be considered objective. Since claims that God commands such and such are either true or false, moral claims are true or false. Basic moral values

[12] Is the third condition met? Perhaps. Rawls's and Korsgaard's appeals are ultimately to fairness and our "practical identity," respectively, not to our desires.

are also universal. God's prohibition of infidelity or murder, for example, extends to all times and places. Furthermore, while God's commands presumably depend on *his* desires, they do not depend on ours. Truth-telling, for instance, is *prima facie* obligatory regardless of what *we* want or desire.[13] Finally, God and his commands are as much part of the furniture of the universe as the stars in their courses or subatomic particles.

Nevertheless, divine command theory is exposed to an important objection. If I am correct, basic moral facts are *necessary* facts. "Lying is *prima facie* wrong" or "Loyalty is a moral excellence," for instance, are *necessarily* true, that is, true in all possible worlds. But if they are, divine command theory seems otiose since moral values meet all four criteria for objectivity *just in virtue of their necessity*. Claims about basic values are either necessarily *true* or necessarily *false*.[14] The values in question are also universal: since propositions expressing basic value facts are necessarily true, they are true in all possible worlds. Our third criterion is met as well. Necessary facts, such as the facts of logic and mathematics, aren't constituted by our willing or desiring them. They thus have the necessary independence of our desires.

Is the fourth criterion met too? It is difficult to see why not. If basic value claims are necessarily true, then the facts that they express are as much a part of the structure of reality as the facts of logic and mathematics. If the latter are rightly regarded as objective, then so too are the former. Moreover, value properties are *real* properties of the things that have them. If it is necessarily true that lying is *prima facie* wrong and that loyalty is a moral excellence, then *prima facie* wrongness and moral excellence are *essential* properties of lying and loyalty, respectively. And essential properties of a thing are surely *real* properties of it.

The objection is therefore this. There is some reason to think that basic value claims are necessarily true. If they are, their objectivity is assured, and there is no reason to bring God into the picture. An appeal to theistic metaphysics is thus otiose. Like facts of logic and mathematics, basic value facts are necessary and so need no further explanation.

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[13] Kant thought that grounding moral precepts in desires would subject morality to the fluctuations and variations of desire, and thus undercut its universality and inescapability. But if God *necessarily* exists, *necessarily* prizes truth telling, and, as a result, *necessarily* commands it, then the moral rightness of truth telling isn't hostage to the potential fluctuations or variations of *anyone's* desires (neither ours nor God's). So a divine command theory which incorporates these claims isn't exposed to Kant's objection.

[14] If true basic value claims are necessarily true, then the *denials* of true basic value claims are necessarily false.

There is, however, an important difference between logical or mathematical facts on the one hand and necessary value facts on the other. The former are logically necessary in the *"narrow"* sense. Their truth is analytic, a consequence of definitions and logical or syntactic rules. Some necessary truths, though, are *not* analytic. Typical examples are "Nothing is red and green all over," "Nothing is larger than itself," or (more controversially) "No contingent being exists without at least a partial reason for its existence." While propositions like these are true in all possible worlds, their truth can't be deduced from definitions and logical rules. The constraints that truths of this sort impose are *substantive*, and not merely *formal*. Perhaps analytic or *narrowly* necessary truths stand in no need of explanation. But synthetic or "*broadly*" necessary truths do. That there is some reason for the existence of contingent beings, for instance, presupposes the world's (at least partial) intelligibility, and that the world *is* intelligible cries out for explanation. Now necessary moral truths aren't analytic either. There is thus more reason for thinking that *these* truths stand in need of explanation than for thinking that the truths of logic and mathematics do.

The metaphysical "queerness" of necessary moral facts can be brought out in another way. On objectivist accounts, the property of moral rightness supervenes on instances of truth-telling, for example, and moral goodness supervenes on certain character types, for instance, those exhibited by Marcus Aurelius, Socrates, and Jeremiah. Furthermore, the connection between the base properties and the supervenient properties is necessary. In any possible world containing instances of truth-telling or a character like Socrates', *prima facie* rightness or moral goodness supervenes on them. Yet the connection between the base property and the supervenient property can seem mysterious. For in the absence of further explanation, the (necessary) connection between these radically different sorts of properties (the psychological properties constituting Socrates' character, for example, and the "non-natural" [that is, non-empirical] property of moral goodness) is just an inexplicable brute fact.

Theistic metaphysics can mitigate this problem since "the theist has a suitably 'queer' world-view into which to fit these 'queer' objects."[15] Divine command theory, for example, explains the connection between truth-telling and *prima facie* rightness by appealing to God's necessary goodness, and the fact that he commands it.

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[15] Robert Gay, "Moral Arguments for the Existence of God," *Modern Theology* 3 (1987), p. 123.

Of course, divine command theory isn't the only theistic (or religious) game in town. There is another way of both securing God's sovereignty and explaining the existence of objective moral obligations, and that is to insist that while moral states of affairs *are* metaphysically dependent on God, they aren't metaphysically dependent on his *willing* them. They might, for example, be metaphysically dependent on his thinking them. Or they might be metaphysically dependent on God's being the Supreme Good or standard of value, so that the existence of the standard contributes to the existence of moral obligations but the existence of moral obligations doesn't contribute to the existence of the standard.[16] Or we might embrace Linda Zagzebski's "divine motivation theory."

"Divine motivation theory makes the ground of what is morally good and morally right God's motives rather than God's will." Divine motivational states "such as love and compassion . . . [which] are components of God's virtues constitute the metaphysical basis for moral value."[17]

Divine motivation theory is "a virtue theory because" it regards "the moral properties of persons" (namely, virtues and vices) as "more basic than the moral properties of acts and outcomes . . . Outcomes [and acts] get their moral value by their relation to good and bad motivations." Good acts, for example, are the sort of acts which express the good emotional dispositions that are constituents of the virtues.[18]

Divine motivation theory is also an "exemplarist" theory in which "the moral properties of persons, acts, and outcomes are defined via an indexical reference to an exemplar of a good person." "The paradigmatically good person," however, "is God . . . God's motives are perfectly good and human motives are good in so far as they are like the divine motives as those motives would be expressed in finite and embodied human beings." Human virtues are good personal traits that "imitate God's virtues" in the

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[16] The theist needs something like this in any case since, if aesthetic or any other values are ontologically independent of God, the sovereignty problem hasn't been fully solved. For a recent attempt to develop a theistic conception of the good which identifies the property referred to by "excellence" with resemblance to the Good, and (following the tradition) the Good with God, see Robert M. Adams, *Finite and Infinite Goods* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1999).

[17] Linda Zagzebski, "Religion and Morality," in William J. Wainwright, ed., *The Oxford Handbook for Philosophy of Religion* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2005), p. 357. (For a more complete statement of Zagzebski's views see her *Divine Motivation Theory* [Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2004].)

[18] Zagzebski, "Religion and Morality," p. 358.

sense that they are the way those virtues "would be expressed by human beings in human circumstances."[19]

Zagzebski thinks that divine motivation theory has several advantages over divine command theory, one of the most important being that in divine command theory, "God's own goodness and the rightness of God's own acts . . . are not connected to divine commands because God does not give commands to himself." Divine motivation theory, on the other hand, "has the theoretical advantage of providing a unitary theory of all [moral] evaluative properties, divine as well as human . . . Both divine and human goodness are explained in terms of God's motives, and the goodness of human motives is derived from the goodness of divine motives."[20]

Whether divine motivation theory is preferable to divine command theory on other counts is another matter. It does seem to do an equally good job of protecting God's sovereignty and independence. If God's motivational states are the metaphysical basis of the goodness or badness of persons and the rightness or wrongness of their actions, then the fact that certain motivational states are good and others bad, and that some human actions are morally right while others are wrong, is not metaphysically independent of God.

On the other hand, the emphasis which Judaism, Christianity, and Islam place on obedience to God seems more at home in a divine command theory than in divine motivation theory considered simply as such. A specifically *Christian* divine motivation theory *may* be able to accommodate it since Christians believe that God was made man in Jesus of Nazareth and hence *does* exhibit the virtue of obedience. In mirroring Jesus' obedience, the Christian's obedience thus mirrors God's own obedience. A move of this sort is not available to *non*-Christian theists, however.

Furthermore, the plausibility of divine motivation theory depends on the plausibility of *virtue* theory. Yet whether virtue theory can adequately account for our sense of moral *obligation* is controversial. Those sympathetic toward Kantian accounts of moral duty and moral obligation will probably judge that it can't since Kantian ethics doesn't comport well with virtue theory.

The *general* point remains, however. Most ethical naturalists and constructivists are metaphysical naturalists; they believe that the space-time world is all there is: the story of the world, in their view, is ultimately a

[19] Ibid.
[20] Ibid., pp. 36of.

story of "atoms, and time and space and economics and politics."[21] But "values and obligations cannot be deep in such a world. They have a grip only upon surface phenomena . . . What is deep" in a world of this sort is "such things as matter and energy, or perhaps natural [i.e., scientific] laws, chance, or chaos." In a Platonic or theistic world, on the other hand, the Good is "much more fundamental to reality than are the atoms," and those who align themselves with the Good align themselves "with what is deepest and most basic in existence."[22] The existence of objective values, or of necessary connections between natural properties and the value properties which supervene upon them, is surely less surprising in a world of this sort than one in which what is deepest is matter, energy, natural law, or chance. As a result, religious views like Platonism or theism can illuminate the existence of objective value in a way in which naturalism cannot: their existence provides reasons for embracing views of this sort. In short, while the existence of objective values is *formally* consistent with a naturalistic metaphysics, it doesn't comport well with it. And, indeed, the unpopularity of moral realism among most committed metaphysical naturalists can be largely attributed to just this sense of incoherence. It is telling, I think, that most naturalistic philosophers share the reaction of theists who believe that the existence of objective values cries out for explanation, but *deny* the existence of objective values because they see no way of providing one.

Appendix

Eric Wielenberg points out that theists like me believe that the propositions "It is *prima facie* wrong to torture small children," for example, and "God exists" are *both* broadly necessary. It is therefore incumbent upon me to explain why I think that the former cries out for an explanation while the latter does not. The two cases seem to me to differ in the following way. God's necessity isn't merely *de dicto* but *de re.* Moreover, the necessity of the proposition that God exists is grounded in his self-existence

[21] C.S. Lewis, *Miracles* (New York: Macmillan, 1947), p. 102.

[22] George Mavrodes, "Religion and the Queerness of Morality," in Robert Audi and William J. Wainwright, eds., *Rationality, Religious Belief, and Moral Commitment* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1986), pp. 224f. Mavrodes's emphasis is rather different from mine, however. His primary concern is with the "queerness," in a naturalistic universe, of objective obligations that would require me to sacrifice my own interests. Mine is on the queerness, in such a universe, of the existence of any objective moral obligations at all.

which (following the tradition) I define as follows: "a self-existent being is essentially causeless; there is no possible world in which it depends on another for its existence. Its existence is also self-explanatory or intrinsically intelligible (though not necessarily intelligible *to us*); if we could grasp its nature we would see *why* it exists." The notion of self-existence (and especially that of intrinsic intelligibility) is doubtless somewhat opaque. It isn't obvious nonsense, however, and provides a way of distinguishing between the two cases. For, in the first place, facts about moral obligations don't seem to be essentially causeless. An indication of this is that we can coherently conceive that they have causes. Divine command theories, for example, aren't obviously incoherent. In the second place, the existence of objective moral facts in a naturalistic universe doesn't seem to be intrinsically intelligible. Like G.E. Moore, Wielenberg believes that objective moral properties necessarily supervene on the natural properties which subvene them. But as J.L. Mackie has said, objective value properties of this sort would, if real, be "queer" properties, "utterly different from anything else in the universe." Their existence isn't self-explanatory. For, as I said earlier, while their existence may be *formally* consistent with a naturalistic metaphysics, it doesn't comport well with it.[23]

[23] Significant portions of this essay are drawn from my Religion and Morality, Aldershot (Eng.) & Burlington, VT: Ashgate 2005.